



Only Monsters Remain

A Curated Witcher 3 Modlist & Game Guide

A Witcher 3 Modlist & Game Guide

Generated 25 July 2026

Table of Contents

Installation & Setup	4
Game Installation	4
Mod Manager Setup	4
Modlist — Wave 0	4
Pre-requisites (installed manually)	4
Foundation (installed via Mod Manager)	5
Beginner's Guide	6
Welcome to the Continent	6
Core Gameplay Loop	6
Understanding the HUD	6
Meditation Mechanics	6
Controls & UI	7
Keyboard & Mouse	7
Controller (Xbox / PlayStation)	7
Navigation	7
Combat Basics	7
Core Combat Flow	7
Attack Types	8
The Five Signs	8
Combat Tips	8
Progression Guide	8
How Leveling Works	8
Skill Trees	8
Beginner Build (Levels 1u201315)	8
Gear Progression	8
Mutagens	9
Difficulty Selection	9
Upgrading to Wave 1	10
Modlist — Wave 1	10
Advanced Strategy	10
Build Archetypes	10
Hybrid Builds	10
Stat Priority	11
Advanced Combat	11
Enemy Weaknesses	11
Oils	11
Bombs	11
Advanced Techniques	11
Gear & Crafting	12
Witcher Gear Sets	12
Grandmaster Crafting (Blood and Wine)	12
Runewords (Hearts of Stone)	12
Gwent Guide	12
Rules	12
Factions	12
Deck Building	12
Exploration	13
The ? System	13
Places of Power	13
Upgrading to Wave 2	14
Modlist — Wave 2	14
Roleplay Background	14

The Legend of the White Wolf	14
Suggested Playthrough Rules	14
Mastery Mechanics	14
Combat Changes	14
Economy Changes	15
Adaptation Guide	15
Specialized Builds	15
Mutation Unlock Guide	15
Endgame & NG+	15
When to Start NG+	15
Blood and Wine Endgame	15
Hearts of Stone Endgame	15
Reference	16
Complete Mod Reference	16
Load Order Guidelines	16
Mod Manager Guide	16
Troubleshooting	16

WAVE 0

A Witcher's Apprentice

Vanilla + Quality of Life — For New Players

Tip: This wave introduces no gameplay-changing mods. Only UI and quality-of-life improvements so you experience the vanilla game as CD Projekt Red intended, just with fewer frustrations.

Installation & Setup

Game Installation

Before modding, you need a clean installation. Install via GOG, Steam, or Epic Games Store and download The Witcher 3: Wild Hunt — Game of the Year Edition.

Verify your game version is **4.04** (released July 19, 2023). On Steam, right-click the game in your library, go to Properties → Betas, and select “4.04” from the dropdown. GOG Galaxy and Epic auto-update.

Launch the game once to generate configuration files. This creates the `dx12filelist.txt` and `dx11filelist.txt` that mod managers use to detect installed mods.

Mod Manager Setup

The Witcher 3 Mod Manager

Download from Nexus Mods (ID: 2678). This is the recommended tool for this modlist.

Step-by-step setup:

1. Launch the Mod Manager
2. Go to Settings and set your game directory (where `witcher3.exe` lives)
3. The Mod Manager scans your `Mods/` folder and detects any existing mods
4. Click Profiles → New Profile and name it “**Only Monsters Remain — Wave 0**”
5. Enable **Script Merger** integration in settings
6. Enable **Mod Deactivation** for easy profile switching

After installing all mods for a wave, click the **Script Merger** button in the Mod Manager, accept auto-merge suggestions, and apply the merged output.

Modlist — Wave 0

The mods listed below are UI and quality-of-life improvements only. They make the game more comfortable without altering combat, progression, economy, or world mechanics.

Pre-requisites (installed manually)

Ultimate ASI Loader

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: ThirteenAG
Version: x64

Category: Utilities
Wave: 0

Required for Mod Limit Adjuster. Download the x64 release and place dinput8.dll in the game root directory.

Mod Limit Adjuster

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: LHSQ & sedmelluq
Version: 1.0

Category: Utilities
Wave: 0

text(size: 9pt, fill: c.muted)[**Dependencies:** Ultimate ASI Loader]

Raises the game's built-in mod limit. Requires ASI Loader, Hearts of Stone, and Blood and Wine. Install ModLimitAdjuster.asi and .cfg to game root.

Script Merger

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: AnotherSymbiote
Version: 0.6.4

Category: Utilities
Wave: 0

Detects and resolves mod conflicts by merging files or configuring load order. Run after installing each batch of mods.

Foundation (installed via Mod Manager)

Community Patch - Shared Imports

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: rmemr
Version: v0.6

Category: Utilities
Wave: 0

Shared class imports baseline that reduces merge conflicts between mods. Provides fully imported engine classes as a common dependency layer.

Community Patch - Menu Strings

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: wghost81
Version: 1.0

Category: Utilities
Wave: 0

Pre-made localized strings for Options > Mods menu subcategories. Resolves the 10-entry menu limit by providing standardized submenu categories.

Community Patch - Bootstrap and Utilities

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: rmemr
Version: 0.5-NEXT-GEN

Category: Utilities
Wave: 0

text(size: 9pt, fill: c.muted)[**Dependencies:** Shared Imports, Menu Strings]

Autostartup framework for mods, custom area hub support, reusable list menu, and utility functions. Reduces merge conflicts by eliminating the need for mods to modify vanilla scripts for startup.

Brothers In Arms - Ultimate Edition

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: MerseyRockoff et al.
Version: 3.1.2

Category: Bug Fixes
Wave: 0

text(size: 9pt, fill: c.muted)[**Dependencies:** Hearts of Stone, Blood and Wine]

5,825 bug fixes and restored content spanning the entire campaign and both expansions. Optional content can be toggled in-game via Options > Mods > Brothers In Arms.

Clever Main Menu (Redux)

[\[Download\]](#)

Author: RoyanFrost
Version: 1.1

Category: UI
Wave: 0

text(size: 9pt, fill: c.muted)[**Dependencies:** Hearts of Stone, Blood and Wine]

Customizable main menu with infinite mod categories, quick save/load via ESC, and extensive visual customization. Requires editing dx11filelist.txt and dx12filelist.txt after install.

Beginner's Guide

Welcome to the Continent

You are **Geralt of Rivia**, a witcher — a genetically enhanced monster hunter for hire. The world is at war. The Nilfgaardian Empire has invaded the Northern Kingdoms, and peasants, soldiers, and monsters alike struggle to survive.

Your goal: find **Ciri**, your adopted daughter, being pursued by the Wild Hunt.

Core Gameplay Loop

1. **Explore** the world
2. **Take contracts** u2014 help villagers by slaying monsters
3. **Complete quests** u2014 main story, side quests, contracts, treasure hunts
4. **Level up** u2014 earn experience, unlock skills, craft better gear
5. **Prepare** u2014 read the bestiary, apply oils, brew potions before fights

Tip: Save often. Use quicksave (F5) before every contract, and manual saves before major story decisions.

Understanding the HUD

- Vitality (top-left red bar) — your health. Zero means death.
- Stamina (top-left yellow bar) — used for Signs and dodging.
- Quickslots (bottom center) — potions, bombs, crossbow bolts.
- Minimap (top-right) — nearby points of interest, quest markers, enemies.
- Quest tracker (upper-left) — active quest objective and distance.
- Toxicity (top-left green bar) — appears after using potions. Too high and you take damage.

Meditation Mechanics

Meditation (Ctrl or hold Start):

- Restores health on lower difficulties (not Death March)
- Advances time — some monsters only spawn at night
- Refills potions by consuming one unit of strong alcohol from your inventory

Tip: Always carry at least 10 Dwarven Spirit or Alcohest. Without alcohol, meditation won't refill your potions.

Controls & UI

Keyboard & Mouse

Action	Key
Move	W / A / S / D
Sprint	Shift (hold)
Dodge	Alt + direction
Roll	Double-tap direction or Alt + double-tap
Light Attack	Left mouse button
Heavy Attack	Right mouse button (hold)
Cast Sign	Q
Draw / Sheathe Steel Sword	1
Draw / Sheathe Silver Sword	2
Use Quickslot	Z / X / C / V
Open Inventory	I
Open Character / Skills	C
Open Map	M
Open Journal / Bestiary	J
Open Alchemy	B
Meditation	Ctrl
Quick Save	F5
Quick Load	F9

Controller (Xbox / PlayStation)

Action	Button
Move	Left stick
Sprint	Left stick (click)
Light Attack	RB / R1
Heavy Attack	RT / R2
Cast Sign	LB / L1 + face button
Dodge	A / Cross + direction
Roll	A / Cross + double-tap direction
Parry	LB / L1 (tap before enemy hits)
Open Inventory	Back / Select
Open Map	Start / Options
Meditation	Hold Start / Options

Navigation

- Roach (your horse): summon by holding Whistle. Gallop with sprint.
- Fast travel: unlock signposts by interacting with them once. Open the world map and click any unlocked signpost.

Combat Basics

Core Combat Flow

1. Read the bestiary before the contract
2. Apply the right oil to your silver sword (+50% damage)

3. Cast Quen before engaging (absorbs one hit)
4. Use the right Sign during the fight
5. Dodge and reposition u2014 never stand still

Attack Types

- Light Attack u2014 fast, chains into 3-hit combo. Low stamina. Primary damage source.
- Heavy Attack u2014 slow, powerful. Breaks guards. High stamina.
- Parry u2014 blocks attacks. Humanoids only.
- Counter u2014 tap Parry as attack lands. Staggers briefly.
- Dodge u2014 quick sidestep. Low stamina. Main defensive move.
- Roll u2014 invincibility frames. Higher stamina. Use for area attacks.

The Five Signs

Sign	Effect	Best Against
Aard	Telekinetic blast	Shielded humans, group packs
Igni	Fire damage, burning	Necrophages, monster nests
Yrden	Magic trap, slows	Wraiths, foglets, fast enemies
Quen	Damage shield	Everything
Axii	Stuns / mind-control	Humans, dialog checks

Tip: Quen is the most important Sign for new players. Keep it active at all times. It absorbs one hit and buys time to react.

Combat Tips

1. Never fight fair — use bombs, traps, potions, and the environment
2. Dodge toward attacks u2014 many enemy swings miss if you step inside their range
3. Igni destroys monster nests u2014 free XP and materials
4. Aard knocks down enemies u2014 follow with one-hit kill prompt
5. Crossbow one-shots flying enemies and works underwater

Progression Guide

How Leveling Works

Experience (XP) comes from:

- Main quests u2014 100-500 XP
- Side quests u2014 50-200 XP
- Witcher contracts u2014 50-150 XP
- Discovering locations u2014 5-10 XP
- Killing enemies u2014 1-20 XP

Skill Trees

- **Combat** u2014 sword damage, crits, adrenaline gain
- **Signs** u2014 Sign intensity, alternate Sign modes
- **Alchemy** u2014 potion duration, toxicity, bomb effectiveness
- **General** u2014 utility perks, cross-tree bonuses

Beginner Build (Levels 1u201315)

Place 3 points into **Muscle Memory** (Combat, fast attack damage), then 3 into **Precise Blows** (Combat, fast attack crit). For survivability, 1 point in **Gourmet** (General) makes food heal for 20 minutes. Finish with 3 in **Exploding Shield** (Signs).

Gear Progression

1. White Orchard (levels 1-6) u2014 loot everything, buy Temerian armor
2. Velen / Novigrad (levels 6-18) u2014 start Witcher gear scavenger hunts (Griffin)

3. Skellige (levels 18-30) u2014 upgrade to Cat or Bear School gear
4. Endgame (levels 30+) u2014 enhanced, superior, mastercrafted witcher gear

Mutagens

- Red u2014 +Attack Power
- Green u2014 +Alchemy bonuses
- Blue u2014 +Sign Intensity

Slot 3 same-color skills adjacent to a matching mutagen for a 3x multiplier. Upgrade 3 of the same type to Greater versions for stronger effects.

Difficulty Selection

Difficulty	Description
Just the Story	Very easy, generous auto-regen
Sword and Story	Moderate. Recommended for first-time players.
Blood and Broken Bones	Challenging. Enemies deal more damage.
Death March	Maximum difficulty. No auto-regen. For veterans.

WAVE 1

A Witcher's Journey

Enhanced Graphics & Content — For Experienced Players

Tip: This wave adds visual enhancements and new content. You should be comfortable with the base game's mechanics before installing Wave 1 mods.

Upgrading to Wave 1

1. Create a new Mod Manager profile: "Only Monsters Remain — Wave 1"
2. Copy your Wave 0 mods to the new profile
3. Install Wave 1 mods (listed below)
4. Run Script Merger
5. Verify load order against the Reference section

Performance Note

Wave 1 includes graphics mods. If you experience frame rate drops, disable the most demanding mods first (lighting overhauls, HD texture packs) rather than lowering in-game settings significantly.

Modlist — Wave 1

All Wave 0 mods plus graphics, content, and enhanced UI mods:

<!-- Mod entries will be added here once the modlist is finalized. -->

Advanced Strategy

Build Archetypes

Combat-Focused u2014 Maximize fast attack damage, crit chance, crit damage. Use adrenaline for finishers. Best for active swordplay.

Sign-Focused u2014 Maximize Sign intensity to control the battlefield. Alternate Sign modes (Yrden turret, Igni stream). Best for tactical players.

Alchemy-Focused u2014 Maximize toxicity to run multiple decoctions for passive bonuses. Best for preparative players.

Hybrid Builds

Combat + Alchemy (Euphoria) u2014 Euphoria mutation converts toxicity into attack power and Sign intensity. With 3+ decoctions, this is the strongest build in the game.

Sign + Combat (Piercing Cold) u2014 Aard freezes enemies solid for instant kills. Combine with sword damage against frozen enemies.

Alchemy + Signs (Conductors of Magic) u2014 Sign intensity scales with sword damage. Alchemy-enhanced swords make Signs hit harder than pure Sign builds.

Stat Priority

Build	1st Priority	2nd Priority	3rd Priority
Combat Sword	Attack Power	Crit Chance	Crit Damage
Combat Whirl	Stamina Regen	Attack Power	Adrenaline Gain
Signs	Sign Intensity	Stamina Regen	Quen / Alternate
Alchemy Euphoria	Toxicity	Decoction Duration	Bomb Radius

Advanced Combat

Enemy Weaknesses

Necrophages (drowners, ghouls, rotfiends) u2014 Weak to fire (Igني) and Necrophage oil. Yrden slows them. Their attacks are telegraphed.

Specters (noonwraiths, nightwraiths) u2014 Weak to Moon Dust bombs and Specter oil. Yrden makes them tangible. Fight during the day.

Ogroids (trolls, golems, gargoyles) u2014 Weak to Northern Wind bombs and Ogroid oil. Aard interrupts their heavy swings.

Beasts (wolves, bears, werewolves) u2014 Weak to Grapeshot and Beast oil. Axii stuns them. Werewolves regenerate u2014 use Moon Dust or Igني.

Draconids (wyverns, forktails, basilisks) u2014 Weak to Draconid oil. Crossbow shots knock them out of the sky.

Elementals (golems, elementals, ice giants) u2014 Weak to Elementa oil. Igني deals bonus damage. Dodge, don't parry.

Oils

Oil	Enemy Type
Beast Oil	Wolves, bears, panthers, werewolves
Necrophage Oil	Drowners, ghouls, rotfiends, wraiths
Elementa Oil	Golems, elementals, ice giants
Draconid Oil	Wyverns, forktails, basilisks
Vampire Oil	Ekimmaras, katakans, bruxae
Specter Oil	Noonwraiths, nightwraiths, plagues
Hanged Man's Venom	Humans

Bombs

- Grapeshot u2014 physical damage, staggers. All-purpose.
- Northern Wind u2014 freezes enemies solid for instant kills.
- Dancing Star u2014 fire damage, burning. Good against necrophages.
- Moon Dust u2014 prevents specter phasing. Essential for wraiths.
- Dimeritium Bomb u2014 disables magic enemies.
- Samum u2014 stuns and blinds. Crowd control.
- Dragon's Dream u2014 flammable gas + Igني = massive explosion.

Advanced Techniques

- Counter u2014 tap parry just as enemy attack lands. Staggers humanoids.
- Rend (Heavy skill) u2014 hold heavy attack to charge. Armor-piercing.
- Whirl (Light skill) u2014 hold light attack to spin. Hits multiple enemies.
- Essential potions: Swallow (heal), Thunderbolt (+attack), Cat (night vision), White Raffard's (instant heal), Maribor Forest (adrenaline), White Honey (clear toxicity).

Gear & Crafting

Witcher Gear Sets

School	Weight	Primary Bonus	Best For
Griffin	Medium	+Sign Intensity	Sign builds
Cat (Feline)	Light	+Attack Power, +Crit	Combat builds
Bear (Ursine)	Heavy	+Adrenaline, +Defense	Tank builds
Wolf	Medium	+Mixed stats	Hybrid builds
Viper	Light	+Poison immunity	Story / NG+
Manticore	Medium	+Alchemy bonuses	Alchemy builds

Diagrams found via Scavenger Hunt quests. Buy maps from blacksmiths and armorers.

Grandmaster Crafting (Blood and Wine)

3-piece and 6-piece set bonuses at the Grandmaster Smith in Beauclair:

- Griffin: +40% Yrden size / Cast Signs while dodging
- Feline: 20% bleed on crit / +20% attack power after kill
- Ursine: 15% damage reduction / Adrenaline not consumed on hit
- Wolf: +25% crit damage / +25% bomb damage
- Manticore: +10% crit chance / +100% bomb damage

Runewords (Hearts of Stone)

Unlock at the Runewright in Upper Novigrad (35,000 crowns for all three tiers).

- Levity u2014 heavy armor counts as light
- Severance u2014 +2 range to Whirl and Rend
- Preservation u2014 gear never degrades
- Invigoration u2014 over-healing increases damage
- Prolongation u2014 potions extend on kill
- Entanglement u2014 Yrden traps follow you

Gwent Guide

Rules

Gwent is played over three rounds. Play one card per turn or pass. Total strength on your board wins the round. Win 2 of 3 to win the match.

Factions

Faction	Strength	Weakness
Northern Realms	Card draw from wins	Low individual strength
Nilfgaard	Spy manipulation	Complex synergy
Scoia'tael	Ambush, pass first	Low base strength
Monsters	Swarm, cloning	Weather vulnerable
Skellige	Graveyard synergy	Weak in round 3

Deck Building

1. Minimum 22 unit cards u2014 remove weakest first
2. Include spies (draw 2 cards) for card advantage
3. Include decoy to reuse medics or spies
4. Include scorch and biting frost as counters
5. Hero cards (gold border) are immune to scorch and weather

Exploration

The ? System

Discoverable locations include: Places of Power (free skill points), hidden treasures (relic gear), monster nests (destroy with Igni), abandoned sites, and smuggler's caches.

Places of Power

Region	Count	Total Skill Points
White Orchard	6	6
Velen	15	15
Novigrad	5	5
Skellige	18	18
Toussaint (BoW)	5	5

Fully explore White Orchard before leaving u2014 it becomes partially inaccessible.

WAVE 2

Master Witcher

Mechanics Overhauls — For Veteran Players

Tip: Wave 2 introduces gameplay overhauls. Only install if you have completed the main game and both expansions at least once.

Upgrading to Wave 2

1. Create a new Mod Manager profile: “Only Monsters Remain — Wave 2”
2. Copy Wave 1 mods to the new profile
3. Install Wave 2 mods (listed below)
4. Run Script Merger
5. Start a New Game+ or fresh save

Modlist — Wave 2

All previous mods plus mechanics overhauls and advanced gameplay mods:

<!-- Mod entries will be added here once the modlist is finalized. -->

Roleplay Background

The Legend of the White Wolf

You’ve walked the Path for decades. The Trial of the Grasses is a distant memory. You’ve seen the best and worst of the Continent. Now the monsters have adapted — they’re smarter, faster, deadlier. Old tactics fail. New ones must be forged.

- **School:** Your choice (Wolf, Cat, Bear, Griffin, Viper, Manticore)
- **Age:** Older, wiser, slower but more precise
- **Motto:** “Monsters come in many shapes. The worst ones wear human faces.”

Suggested Playthrough Rules

1. Read the bestiary before every contract
2. Apply the correct oil before every fight
3. Only fast travel between regions (signpost to signpost)
4. Meditate only at inns, taverns, or your own bed
5. Wear your School’s witcher gear
6. Complete contracts before main quests
7. Use each Sign situationally u2014 no spamming

Mastery Mechanics

Combat Changes

- Damage rebalance u2014 fights are shorter and more lethal
- Stamina matters u2014 dodging and Signs share a pool
- Parry windows tighten u2014 enemies feint and vary timing

Economy Changes

- Reduced loot u2014 earn coin through contracts, not looting
- Crafting costs more u2014 hunt specific monsters for rare parts
- Weight matters u2014 carry less, choose carefully

Adaptation Guide

1. Prepare thoroughly u2014 read the bestiary for every contract
2. Use everything u2014 oils, bombs, potions, decoctions, terrain
3. Avoid fair fights u2014 use traps, environmental hazards, choke points
4. Invest in alchemy u2014 dramatically more valuable at higher difficulty
5. Position, don't dodge u2014 stamina is precious

Specialized Builds

Euphoria Alchemy Tank u2014 Mutation: Euphoria. Gear: Manticore. Run 3-4 decoctions. Rnd for damage. Priority: Toxicity > Attack Power > Vitality.

Piercing Cold Signs u2014 Mutation: Piercing Cold. Gear: Griffin. Freeze with Aard, execute. Igni stream, Yrden turret. Priority: Sign Intensity > Stamina Regen.

Deadly Precision Critical u2014 Mutation: Metamorphosis. Gear: Feline. Glass cannon, Whirl, crits. Apply status effects for random buffs. Priority: Crit Chance > Crit Damage > Attack Power.

Conductors of Magic Hybrid u2014 Mutation: Conductors of Magic. Gear: Wolf. Alternate Signs and sword. Adapt to any enemy.

Mutation Unlock Guide

- Euphoria u2014 Blood and Wine main quest ("The Wine Wars")
- Piercing Cold u2014 Blood and Wine side quest (explore unseen area)
- Conductors of Magic u2014 Blood and Wine main quest progression
- Metamorphosis u2014 Blood and Wine side quest (defeat unseen elder)

Endgame & NG+

When to Start NG+

Complete the main quest (level 30+). Finish both expansions first u2014 mutations are valuable in NG+. Recommended: level 50+.

Carries over: Level, skills, mutations, formulas (not crafted potions), Gwent cards, diagrams, gold, inventory.

Resets: Quest progress, world state, discoveries, signposts.

Blood and Wine Endgame

- Hanse bases u2014 repeatable combat, great for leveling
- Grandmaster crafting u2014 tier 6 witcher gear
- Mutation system u2014 12 unique mutations
- Corvo Bianco u2014 renovate your vineyard

Hearts of Stone Endgame

- Runewright u2014 unlock all 3 tiers (35,000 crowns)
- Ofieri quests u2014 unique gear and rewards
- Legendary items u2014 Iris (steel sword), Viper School gear

Reference

Complete Mod Reference

<!-- Full mod metadata table will be populated once the modlist is finalized. -->

Load Order Guidelines

Install mods in this general order:

1. Core frameworks and libraries
2. Graphics and textures
3. UI and HUD changes
4. Gameplay tweaks
5. Content mods
6. Overhauls

Mod Manager Guide

See the full guide at: [Witcher 3 Mod Manager](#).

Features: profile management, script merging, load order control, mod deactivation.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Solution
Game crashes on launch	Run Script Merger. Check dependencies.
Script compilation errors	Delete mod0000_MergedFiles/ and re-merge.
Missing textures	Reinstall the texture mod. Verify game files.
Low FPS after Wave 1	Disable demanding mods first.
Mod not showing in manager	Check archive. Try manual install.
Profiles not switching	Restart Mod Manager. Confirm profile selected.